

A small amount of wealth means the ability to take a few days off work when you're sick without breaking the bank. Gaining that ability is huge if you don't have it.

A bit more means waiting for a good job to come around after you get laid off, rather than having to take the first one you find. That can be life changing.

Six months' emergency expenses means not being terrified of your boss, because you know you won't be ruined if you have to take some time off to find a new job.

More still means the ability to take a job with lower pay but flexible hours. Maybe one with a shorter commute. Or being able to deal with a medical emergency without the added burden of worrying about how you'll pay for it.

Then there's retiring when you want to, instead of when you need to.

Using your money to buy time and options has a lifestyle benefit few luxury goods can compete with.

Throughout college I wanted to be an investment banker. There was only one reason why: they made a lot of money. That was the only drive, and one I was 100% positive would make me happier once I got it. I scored a summer internship at an investment bank in Los Angeles in my junior year, and thought I won the career lottery. This is all I ever wanted.

On my first day I realized why investment bankers make a lot of money: They work longer and more controlled hours than I knew humans could handle. Actually, most can't handle it. Going home before midnight was considered a luxury, and there was a saying in the office: "If you don't come to work on Saturday, don't bother coming back on Sunday." The job was intellectually stimulating, paid well, and made me feel important. But every waking second of my time became a slave to my boss's demands, which was enough to turn it into one of the most miserable experiences of my life. It was a four-month internship. I lasted a month.

The hardest thing about this was that I loved the work. And I wanted to work hard. But doing something you love on a schedule you can't control can feel the same as doing something you hate.